inconsequential. I'd switch back into game mode six or seven minutes before resumption, when the mental checklist would once again be employed.

It's all about the maintenance of routine. I batted, without fail, on arriving at the ground. That might merely be facing underarm bowling from coaches, but I would always be wearing pads. Some players – Hashim Amla, for example – don't bother to wear pads, but we are all, at heart, creatures of habit. I have never forgotten being pulled up by Graham Gooch at the age of nineteen, when I netted wearing only a front pad.

'Would you do that in a game?' he barked. Obviously not. 'Well, don't ever do that again.' It was one of those 0.1 per cent moments that matter in professional sport, a reminder of acceptable standards that lead to marginal gains. We went on to develop a routine in which I'd ask him to throw down at me using the dog-stick to stimulate sharpness. It was our way of making sure we had done everything possible to prepare properly.

I used to enjoy my time as captain once I'd completed the formalities of the toss, especially if we were batting. Ten minutes were taken up with three interviews, with Sky, Channel 5 and BBC radio, leaving another ten or so for me to pad up, and be prepared. That gives the inner voice less scope to start yapping in your ear. The bowlers tap you on the back for postponing the workload, wish you good luck, and you're off.

There's not exactly a randomness about success and failure, but it pays to be pragmatic. It helps to remind yourself that sometimes the odds are simply not in your favour. Test bowlers are paid to take wickets and, by definition, they are the best in their country. They make the most of beneficial conditions.

I've not been out to that many unplayable deliveries, but in about 99 per cent of dismissals you might have done something differently. Some mistakes come with the territory: you could have been drawn into the new ball and nicked off, because it behaved more dangerously than a ball that's thirty-five overs old.

I was once told that Mike Brearley, the captain's captain, used to hum a Rachmaninov quartet when he was batting. My mental musical tastes are less highbrow, easy-listening earworms produced by the likes of Razorlight or Queen. I don't sing along, but occasionally hum a sequence, or work through the lyrics. Familiar songs in my head allow me to maintain rhythm.